



AI GUIDE SERIES · BOOK FIVE

# AI for Veterans

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# **AI for Veterans**

*Better Understand Benefits, Healthcare, and  
Government Services*

**AI Guide Series - Book 5**

Patrick Thomas

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Artificial intelligence can be a powerful assistant. It should never replace common sense, professional advice, independent verification, or human judgment.

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# Introduction: A New Tool in Your Arsenal

Marcus is an illustrative composite. Like many veterans, he had years of records, several conditions, and a denial letter he did not fully understand. Instead of uploading his claim file or medical records to a public AI service, he created a short, de-identified timeline from his own notes. He asked an AI tool to explain unfamiliar terms and help organize questions for an accredited Veterans Service Organization representative.

The AI did not determine eligibility, supply medical evidence, or predict a rating. Marcus verified the public information on VA.gov and in Title 38, corrected errors in the AI response, and brought his organized questions and records to his representative. The useful result was not a promised award. It was a clearer conversation with a qualified human.

## What This Book Is

This book shows how AI can help you read public information, organize non-sensitive notes, prepare questions, improve your own writing, and translate military experience into civilian language. It also shows where AI should stop.

AI is not a claims representative, clinician, benefits calculator, or eligibility authority. It can invent regulations, misstate deadlines, misunderstand medical evidence, and produce confident but incorrect answers. Use it to prepare - not to decide.

## What This Book Covers

Part One introduces AI and privacy-safe prompting. Part Two covers disability claims and claim examinations. Part Three addresses healthcare navigation and mental-health support. Part Four covers education, career transition, and financial programs. Part Five covers federal, state, and local resources. Part Six addresses scams and provides an action plan.

## **A Word About Skepticism**

Skepticism is useful. Require important claims to be traceable to a current official source. Keep sensitive records out of general-purpose AI tools unless an approved system and its privacy terms make that use appropriate. Bring consequential questions to the agency, an accredited representative, or another qualified professional.

The goal is not to make AI the authority. The goal is to help you arrive at the right authority better prepared.

# Part One



# Chapter 1: What AI Actually Is (And Why You Should Care)

Let's skip the hype.

You've probably seen the headlines - AI is going to change everything, AI is going to take everyone's jobs, AI is either going to save humanity or end it depending on which article you read last. None of that is what this chapter is about.

This chapter is about something much more practical: what AI actually is, what it can actually do for you right now, and why a veteran who has never used one of these tools may find the basic capabilities useful.

## What AI Is, Without the Science Fiction

Artificial intelligence - specifically the kind powering the tools we're talking about in this book - is software that has been trained on enormous amounts of text, data, and information to recognize patterns and generate useful responses.

A modern language model predicts useful responses from patterns in its training data and the information supplied in a conversation. It has not necessarily read every relevant regulation, decision, or handbook; it may not have current information; and it does not know whether a generated answer is true. Its value is speed and language assistance, not authority.

For a veteran preparing questions about a denial, learning the rules for secondary service connection, or translating military experience into civilian language, that assistance can be useful when the result is verified.

## The Main AI Tools You'll Use

There are several AI tools worth knowing about. You don't need to use all of them. Pick one and get comfortable with it first.

## **The Main AI Tools For Veterans**

ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Microsoft Copilot are widely used general-purpose assistants. Product names, prices, models, privacy terms, and features change frequently. Review each provider's current official information before choosing one. Start with low-risk tasks and do not assume that a paid plan makes a service appropriate for sensitive records.

## **What AI Is Genuinely Good At**

For veterans specifically, AI excels at four things:

Explaining complex systems in plain language. VA regulations, CFR Title 38, SSDI eligibility rules, GI Bill comparison, state benefit programs - AI can translate all of it from bureaucratic language into something you can actually use.

Organizing information. Organizing a de-identified timeline that you create from your own notes. Building a checklist of questions about your service and symptoms. Creating a checklist of evidence needed for your claim. Structuring a personal statement. These organizational tasks that used to require a paralegal or a very patient VSO can now be done with AI in an afternoon.

Drafting documents. Personal statements, buddy statement guides, cover letters, résumés, appeal letters, letters to your congressional representative. AI produces strong first drafts. You personalize, verify, and own the final product.

Research. Finding official pages to investigate and generating search terms. Building a list of federal and state programs to verify. Looking up your condition's rating criteria. Researching employers who prioritize veteran hiring. AI does this research faster and more comprehensively than manual searching.

## **Where AI Falls Short**

Being honest about limitations is as important as being enthusiastic about capabilities. Here's where AI doesn't replace human expertise:

AI cannot represent you. It cannot file your claim, appear at a Board hearing, or advocate on your behalf with a VA official. A VSO or VA-accredited attorney does that.

AI can be wrong - confidently. This is called hallucination, and it's a real risk. AI can cite a regulation that doesn't exist, give you a rating percentage that's slightly off, or misstate a deadline. Always verify important information from official sources: VA.gov, CFR Title 38, your VSO.

AI doesn't know your specific records. It knows general information. It doesn't know the specific details of your service record, your medical history, or your claim file. You provide the specific facts; AI helps you understand the framework.

AI is not a mental health provider. We'll address AI mental health tools specifically in Chapter 8. For now: AI is not therapy, not crisis intervention, and not a substitute for care.

## **Myth vs. Reality**

MYTH: AI is only for tech-savvy young people.

REALITY: The veterans getting the most out of AI tools today include many who had never used them before picking up this book. These tools are designed to be conversational - you talk to them the way you'd talk to a knowledgeable person. No coding, no technical background, no special equipment required.

## **Why Veterans Specifically Have So Much to Gain**

The VA system is one of the most complex bureaucratic environments in the United States. The regulations governing disability ratings run to thousands of pages. The appeals process has multiple lanes with different timelines and standards. The benefits landscape - VA, DoD, SSA, state, local - is fragmented across dozens of agencies with overlapping and sometimes conflicting rules.

Navigating this system has historically required either significant personal research, access to an experienced VSO, the money to hire a

VA-accredited attorney, or the luck of knowing the right people. AI does not replace those resources. It can make some public information easier to explore, but access, accuracy, connectivity, disability accommodations, and digital literacy vary among veterans.

That's not a small thing. That's the information gap closing.

## **Try This Now**

Right now - before you finish this chapter - try this:

Open any AI tool (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or Copilot). Type this prompt:

"I'm a veteran with [describe your branch, years of service, and one condition you deal with]. Can you give me a plain-language overview of how VA disability ratings work for this type of condition, and what evidence I would typically need to support a claim?"

Don't worry about being perfect. Just ask the question. See what comes back. Treat the response as a draft explanation. Verify it before deciding what to do.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 AI is software trained on vast amounts of information that can explain complex systems, organize documents, draft text, and conduct research - all in plain language, on demand.
- 2 The main tools - ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot - are free or low-cost and require no technical background to use.
- 3 AI excels at explaining VA regulations, organizing evidence, drafting documents, and researching benefits.
- 4 AI cannot represent you, can be wrong, and is not a mental health provider. Always verify important information from official sources.
- 5 Veterans have more to gain from AI than almost any

other group - because the information gap in the VA system is exactly what AI is designed to close.

## Chapter 2: Getting Started: Your First AI Tools

In this illustrative composite, Frank had spent twenty-two years in the Navy as a machinist's mate. He'd troubleshoot nuclear reactor systems under pressure, trained junior sailors, and written maintenance manuals for equipment that cost more than most houses. He was not, by any reasonable measure, someone who struggled with technical things.

But when his daughter suggested he try AI to help with his VA claim, he pushed back. "That's for young people," he said. "I don't even know where to start."

His daughter showed him. She opened Claude on his laptop, typed a question about his hearing loss claim, and read him the response. Frank was quiet for a moment. Then he said: "Ask it about tinnitus ratings."

He was still at the laptop two hours later.

"It's just talking," he said afterward. "You just talk to it. I don't know why I thought it was going to be complicated."

It really is just talking. This chapter shows you how to start - and how to talk to AI in a way that gets you useful answers instead of vague ones.

### Setting Up: What You Need

You need three things: a device (phone, tablet, or computer), an internet connection, and an email address to create a free account. That's it.

On a phone: Go to your app store and search for ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini. Download the app, create a free account with your email, and you're ready.

On a computer: Go to [chatgpt.com](https://chatgpt.com), [claude.ai](https://claude.ai), or [gemini.google.com](https://gemini.google.com). Create a free account. Start typing.

Voice option: All major AI tools now support voice input on mobile. If typing is difficult - arthritis, hand injuries, or just preference - tap the microphone icon and speak your questions. The AI reads back its responses, and you can respond by voice. Many veterans find this more natural than typing.

## **How to Talk to AI: The Basics of Prompting**

A prompt is what you type (or say) to an AI. The quality of what you get back is directly related to how clearly you ask. This doesn't require skill - it requires specificity.

The single most important rule: give context. AI doesn't know who you are, what branch you served in, what your conditions are, or what you're trying to accomplish. The more context you give, the more useful the response.

## **Weak Prompts vs. Strong Prompts**

WEAK: 'How does the VA work?' STRONG: 'I'm an Army veteran with 8 years of service. I

have a lower back injury from a training accident in 2014 that was documented in my service records. I was denied a VA disability claim in 2022 for insufficient nexus. What does a strong nexus look like for this type of claim, and what should my personal statement include?'

WEAK: 'What benefits am I eligible for?' STRONG: 'I'm a 100% P&T disabled veteran, Marine Corps, Gulf War era. I'm 58 years old, married, with two adult children. What federal and state benefits should I be researching beyond my VA compensation? I live in Texas.'

WEAK: 'Help me with my résumé.' STRONG: 'I was an Army 11B infantryman for 12 years, including two combat deployments. I left as an E-7 and managed a team of 12. I want to transition to logistics or operations management. Help me translate my military experience into civilian résumé language for those roles.'

The pattern is: only the context needed for the task, plus a specific goal and a request for official sources. Do not add identifying information merely to make a prompt more detailed.

## **The Follow-Up Is Where the Value Lives**

New AI users often ask one question, read the response, and stop. That's the least effective way to use these tools.

AI is a conversation. The first response is the starting point. Your follow-up questions are where you get to the specific, actionable information you actually need.

After any AI response, ask yourself: What part of this do I need more detail on? What did it mention that I don't understand? What did I not ask that I should have?

Useful follow-up patterns: "Can you explain that in simpler terms?" / "What's the specific regulation that covers that?" / "What evidence would I need to prove that?" / "What are the most common mistakes veterans make with this?" / "What should I ask my VSO about this?"

## **What Not to Share With AI Tools**

AI tools are powerful but they are not private in the way a conversation with your attorney is private. Here's a practical guide to what's safe and what isn't:

### **Watch Out For**

DO NOT share with AI tools:

- Your full Social Security Number
- Your VA file number or claim number
- Complete medical records (summarize instead - describe conditions, dates, symptoms)
- Financial account numbers
- Your full date of birth combined with your full name and



address

- Login credentials for VA.gov, My HealtheVet, or any other account

SAFE to share:

- Your branch of service and years served
- General descriptions of your conditions and symptoms
- Your rating percentage (if you have one)
- Your state of residence
- General descriptions of your service history

The rule: Use AI to understand the system and draft documents. Keep your sensitive identifying information out of it.

## **Three Starter Prompts Every Veteran Should Try**

If you're not sure where to begin, start with one of these. They're designed to give you immediately useful information regardless of your specific situation.

### **Your First Three AI Prompts**

PROMPT 1 - Understand Your Benefits Landscape: "I'm a [branch] veteran with [X] years of service. I currently have a [X]% VA disability rating (or: I have no rating yet). I live in [state]. Can you give me an overview of the major federal and state benefits I should be researching, including any I might not know about?"

PROMPT 2 - Understand a Specific Condition for Claims: "Can you explain in plain language how the VA rates [your condition] under CFR Title 38? What are the rating percentages, what the current regulation says, what evidence categories VA identifies, and which official VA or eCFR pages I should verify?"

PROMPT 3 - Translate Your Military Experience: "I served as a [MOS/rate/AFSC] in the [branch] for [X] years. My key

responsibilities included [brief description]. I'm now looking for civilian work in [field or general area]. Can you translate my military experience into civilian language and suggest job titles I should be searching for?"

Run one of these today. See what comes back. Ask a follow-up question. That's the entire skill. The rest is just practice.

## **Using Voice Input**

For veterans dealing with hand injuries, limited mobility, or who simply find talking more natural than typing, voice input is a game-changer. Many major AI applications and device operating systems support it.

On iPhone: Open the Claude or ChatGPT app. Tap the microphone icon in the text field. Speak your question naturally. The app transcribes it and sends it. You can read the response or have it read to you.

On Android: Same process - look for the microphone icon in the text input area.

On desktop: Most AI tools or the operating system may offer dictation. You can also use your device's built-in dictation feature (Windows key + H on Windows; Fn + D on Mac with newer OS versions) to dictate into any text field.

## **Real Talk**

In another illustrative composite, Dave, a 61-year-old Vietnam-era Marine, had been telling his kids for years that computers 'weren't his thing.' His hands shook slightly from a service-connected condition that made typing frustrating.

His grandson showed him voice input on an iPad. Dave held the tablet like a walkie-talkie and said: 'I need to know what benefits a Vietnam veteran with Agent Orange exposure is eligible for.'

The AI produced a list of topics and official pages for Dave to investigate. He and his grandson checked the claims against VA.gov before treating any item as relevant.

Dave sat up straighter. 'Nobody ever told me about half of this,' he said.

He spent the next hour asking follow-up questions by voice. He hasn't stopped since.

## **When AI Gets Something Wrong**

It will happen. AI tools sometimes state incorrect percentages, misquote regulations, or describe a program slightly inaccurately. This isn't a reason to stop using them - it's a reason to verify important information before acting on it.

The verification rule: For any piece of information that would affect a decision - a rating percentage, a filing deadline, an eligibility requirement - verify it from an official source before relying on it.

Official sources: VA.gov for VA benefits and programs. CFR Title 38 (available free at [ecfr.gov](http://ecfr.gov)) for disability

rating criteria. SSA.gov for Social Security programs. Your VSO for claims-specific guidance.

Think of AI as a very knowledgeable research assistant who occasionally misremembers a detail. You'd still use the research assistant - you'd just double-check the numbers.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 Getting started requires only a device, internet, and a free email account. Voice input makes it accessible regardless of typing ability.
- 2 Strong prompts give context: branch, years of service, specific situation, specific goal. Vague prompts get vague answers.
- 3 The follow-up question is where the real value lives. AI is

a conversation, not a search engine.

- 4 Keep sensitive identifying information - SSN, claim numbers, full medical records - out of AI tools. Describe, don't document.
- 5 Always verify important facts (rating percentages, deadlines, eligibility rules) from official sources before acting on them.

# Part Two

# Chapter 3: Understanding the VA Claims System

VA disability compensation is governed by statutes, regulations, evidence rules, and the facts of an individual record. AI can help explain vocabulary, but VA - not an AI system - decides service connection and the evaluation assigned.

## Service Connection in Plain Language

For a typical direct service-connection claim, the evidence generally needs to address a current disability, an event, injury, disease, or qualifying service circumstance, and a connection between the two. The exact evidence depends on the claim. Medical evidence is often important, but VA may also consider competent lay evidence, service records, presumptions, and evidence developed through VA's duty to assist.

Do not reduce every claim to “get a nexus letter.” A private medical opinion is not automatically required, and a generic or unsupported opinion may carry little weight. Review the evidence notice for the particular claim and discuss gaps with an accredited representative.

## Ratings and Combined Evaluations

VA uses the Schedule for Rating Disabilities in 38 CFR Part 4. Criteria differ by condition, and some evaluations depend on measurements, test results, or overall functional impairment rather than a checklist of symptoms. Multiple evaluations are combined using VA's whole-person method rather than ordinary addition.

An AI explanation or calculator is only an estimate. Verify diagnostic codes and current criteria in the eCFR and use VA's official combined-ratings information or an accredited representative.

## Decision Reviews

Under the modernized review system, the three principal options are:

- **Supplemental Claim:** Submit or identify new and relevant evidence. It may be filed at any time, but filing within one year of the decision is generally important for preserving a potential effective date.
- **Higher-Level Review:** A more senior reviewer considers the existing record. New evidence is not accepted. An optional informal conference can identify alleged factual or legal errors.
- **Board Appeal:** A Veterans Law Judge reviews the appeal using the selected docket: Direct Review, Evidence Submission, or Hearing.

For most VA benefits, Higher-Level Review and Board Appeal requests are due within one year of the decision letter, but exceptions exist and the letter controls. After a Board decision, options may include a Supplemental Claim or an appeal to the U.S. Court of Appeals for Veterans Claims. Representation at the Court is not legally mandatory, but experienced legal assistance is strongly advisable.

## Try This Now

Use AI to prepare questions, not choose a lane:

“Explain the differences among a Supplemental Claim, Higher-Level Review, and Board Appeal using only current VA.gov guidance. Give me the official links and a list of questions to ask an accredited representative. Do not recommend a lane for my case.”

## Chapter Summary

- 1 Evidence requirements depend on the type of claim and the individual record.
- 2 AI explanations and rating calculations are drafts that must be checked against current official sources.
- 3 Supplemental Claims, Higher-Level Reviews, and Board Appeals have different evidence rules.

- 4 Deadlines can affect review rights and effective dates; follow the decision letter and seek timely accredited help.
- 5 VA-accredited representatives can help evaluate an individual case.



# Chapter 4: Using AI to Research Your Claim

The safest research sequence is official source first, AI explanation second, human review when the decision matters.

## Reading Title 38

Begin with the current eCFR or VA.gov page. Copy only a short public passage - not personal records - into the AI tool and ask for a plain-language explanation. Then compare the explanation with the original text.

**Prompt:** “Explain this public regulation in plain language. Separate what the text explicitly says from your interpretation. Do not predict my rating. Here is the passage: [paste short excerpt].”

## Presumptive Service Connection

A presumption may remove the need to prove that qualifying service caused a listed condition, but it does not eliminate every requirement. The veteran still must meet the applicable service, location, exposure, time-period, diagnosis, and other eligibility rules. Lists change, so verify them on VA.gov rather than asking AI to produce a definitive list from memory.

**Prompt:** “Using current VA.gov sources, help me identify which official presumptive-condition pages relate to [service location and dates stated without identifying details]. Quote no personal conclusions. Give me a checklist to verify with an accredited representative.”

## Secondary Service Connection

A new condition may be service connected if evidence shows that an already service-connected disability caused or aggravated it. A condition being commonly discussed alongside another condition is not proof of causation in an individual case. BVA decisions generally apply to their own facts and are not a substitute for current regulations, competent evidence, or accredited advice.

Avoid prompts asking AI to generate “secondary conditions to claim.” Instead ask for the governing rule, evidence categories, and questions for a clinician or representative. Never ask AI to manufacture a medical theory or language for a clinician to sign.

## Building a Research Log

For each question, record:

- The exact issue you are researching
- The official URL and date accessed
- The relevant regulation, form, or VA page
- What remains uncertain
- Questions for an accredited representative or clinician

## Chapter Summary

- 1 Start with current VA.gov and eCFR material.
- 2 Ask AI to explain a supplied public passage rather than recall the law from memory.
- 3 Presumptions still have service and eligibility requirements.
- 4 Association does not prove secondary service connection.
- 5 Keep a source log and take unresolved questions to a qualified human.

# Chapter 5: Writing Your Personal Statement with AI

The personal statement - also called a Statement in Support of Claim (VA Form 21-4138) or a lay statement

- is your opportunity to tell the VA, in your own words, what happened to you and how it affects you today.

It's also one of the most consistently underused and poorly executed elements of VA claims. Veterans who have spent years dealing with a condition often struggle to put it into words in a way that connects to what the VA is actually evaluating. The language that matters to the VA - functional limitations, frequency of symptoms, impact on daily activities and employment - doesn't come naturally to most people describing their own health.

AI can bridge that gap. Not by writing your statement for you - your statement must be yours, in your voice, describing your actual experience. But by helping you understand what to include, how to structure it, and how to make sure the things you know are true come across in language the VA can evaluate.

## What a Strong Personal Statement Includes

A strong personal statement addresses three things clearly and specifically:

The in-service event. What happened, when it happened, where it happened, and how it was documented (or why it might not have been). Specific dates, locations, and unit information add credibility. If there are witnesses, name them.

Current symptoms and functional impact. Not just "my back hurts" - but specifically: how often, how severely, what activities it prevents or limits, how it affects your work, your sleep, your relationships, your daily functioning. The VA rates conditions based on functional limitation. Describe yours.

The nexus - your understanding of the connection. You don't need to be a doctor to say: "My back condition began during my service, was documented in my service medical records, has been continuous since my separation, and has never resolved." Lay the factual groundwork for the medical nexus your doctor will provide.

## **Personal Statement: Before and After AI Assistance**

BEFORE (typical unassisted personal statement): 'I hurt my back in the Army and it still bothers me. I've had back problems since I got out and it makes it hard to do things. I think this should be service connected.'

Problem: No specifics. No functional impact. No nexus language. No dates or locations. Result: Easy to deny.

AFTER (AI-assisted structure, veteran's own words): 'On March 14, 2009, while conducting a loaded ruck march at Fort Bragg, NC, I fell carrying approximately 65 lbs of equipment and injured my lower back. The injury was treated at the post medical facility and is documented in my service treatment records. I was placed on a physical profile limiting my activities for six weeks.

Since that injury, I have had continuous lower back pain that has never fully resolved. Currently, I experience sharp pain rated 6-8/10 approximately 4-5 days per week. I cannot stand for more than 20 minutes or sit for more than 30 minutes without significant pain. I have been unable to work in jobs requiring physical activity and was terminated from a warehouse position in 2019 due to inability to lift.',

Same veteran. Same injury. Completely different claim.

## **How to Work With AI on Your Statement**

The process that works best: you tell the AI your story in your own words - everything you remember, in any order - and then work with AI to structure and strengthen it. AI asks clarifying questions, identifies gaps, and helps you find the functional language that connects your experience to what the VA evaluates.

## **SAMPLE PROMPTS FOR YOUR PERSONAL STATEMENT**

STEP 1 - Tell your story: "I'm writing a VA personal statement for a [condition] claim. Here's what happened: [describe your in-service event in your own words]. My current symptoms are: [describe how you feel now]. Help me identify what's missing and what I should add."

STEP 2 - Get the functional language right: "I told you my back hurts a lot. Can you help me describe this in terms of specific functional limitations - what I can and can't do - using language that will be meaningful to a VA rater evaluating a lumbar spine claim?"

STEP 3 - Check for clarity without predicting a rating: "Review this draft only for chronology, clarity, and missing factual context. Do not suggest symptoms, predict a rating, or add anything I did not state."

STEP 4 - Final review: "Review my draft personal statement and tell me: what's

strong, what's weak, what's missing, and what might raise questions for a VA rater?"

### **The Critical Rule: AI Drafts, You Own**

This cannot be overstated: your personal statement must describe your actual experience in your actual words. It must be true. AI can help you structure, strengthen, and complete a statement about your real experience - it cannot fabricate or exaggerate that experience for you.

Beyond the ethical issue, there's a practical one: the VA will compare your personal statement to your medical records, your service records, and your C&P examination. Inconsistencies are red flags.

Exaggerations create credibility problems that can sink an otherwise strong claim.

Use AI to make your true story as clear and complete as possible. That's all it needs to do.

## Watch Out For

Personal statement mistakes that AI can help you avoid - but that you must watch for:

- Vague symptom descriptions ('it hurts a lot') with no functional specifics
- Missing dates and locations for in-service events
- No description of continuity - show the condition has been ongoing since service
- Inconsistency with your medical records (AI can flag this if you describe both)
- Over-reliance on diagnostic labels without describing actual experienced symptoms
- Failing to describe impact on work, relationships, and daily activities

**NEVER:** Submit AI-generated content as your own statement without reading, personalizing, and verifying every sentence. Your signature means it's yours.

## Chapter Summary

- 1 A strong personal statement addresses three things: the in-service event (specific details), current functional impact (what you can and can't do), and the factual nexus (continuous since service).
- 2 AI helps you structure and strengthen your statement - but your statement must describe your real experience in your own words.
- 3 Use AI to translate your experience into functional language that connects to VA rating criteria.

- 4 Work iteratively: tell AI your story, get structural feedback, check the facts against your own records, then review the draft.
- 5 Never submit AI output without personalizing and verifying every sentence. Inconsistency with medical records creates credibility problems.

# Chapter 6: Buddy Statements, C&P Exams, and Supporting Evidence

Buddy statements and claim examinations can provide important evidence, but accuracy matters more than performance or strategy.

## Buddy Statements

A lay or witness statement may describe an in-service event or firsthand observations of symptoms and functional effects. The writer should explain the relationship to the veteran, what was personally observed, when and where it occurred, and how often it has been observed. The writer should not diagnose a condition or repeat facts learned only from someone else as firsthand knowledge.

AI can provide a neutral outline, but the witness must supply and approve every fact in the witness's own words. Do not upload private records or ask AI to make the statement sound more severe.

## Preparing for a Claim Examination

A C&P examination gathers information for a benefits decision; it is not ordinary treatment. Review the appointment notice, confirm the location and time, and bring permitted records or assistive devices as instructed. VA may allow a caregiver or family member to attend, subject to the examiner's judgment.

Describe symptoms truthfully across time: typical severity, frequency, duration, functional effects, treatment, and what happens during flare-ups. Do not present the worst day as the everyday baseline, minimize symptoms to appear stoic, exaggerate, rehearse invented answers, or intentionally restrict effort. If a question is unclear, ask for clarification.



For certain reproductive, breast, rectal, mental-health, or MST-related examinations, VA permits a request for a male or female provider. Making the request may require a change in time or location.

## **A Safer Preparation Prompt**

“Using the current official VA claim-exam page, create a neutral preparation checklist for a [condition] examination. Do not coach me toward a rating or suggest symptoms. Include reminders to describe typical symptoms, frequency, duration, flare-ups, and functional effects accurately.”

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 Lay statements should contain specific firsthand observations.
- 2 AI may provide an outline, but the witness owns the facts and wording.
- 3 Describe typical severity and flare-ups honestly - not only the best or worst day.
- 4 Do not exaggerate, minimize, or perform for an examination.
- 5 Verify accommodations and examination procedures with VA or the contractor.

# Part Three

# Chapter 7: Navigating VA Healthcare with AI

The VA healthcare system serves over nine million veterans at more than 1,200 facilities nationwide. It is, by

many measures, one of the largest integrated healthcare systems in the world. It is also one of the most difficult to navigate without a guide.

Appointment backlogs. Referral processes. Secure messaging. My HealtheVet. Community Care. The MISSION Act. Understanding what you're entitled to, how to access it, and how to make the most of every appointment requires navigating a system that wasn't designed with the individual veteran's ease in mind.

AI doesn't fix the system. But it gives you tools to work within it more effectively - understanding your diagnoses, preparing for appointments, knowing your rights, and using the VA's own digital tools more productively.

## Understanding Your Diagnoses and Medications

One of the most immediately useful applications of AI for VA healthcare: asking general questions about diagnoses and medications in plain language while protecting health information.

Medical terminology can be difficult to absorb during an appointment. AI may help explain general public information, but it cannot determine what a diagnosis or medication means for an individual. Use the explanation to prepare questions for a clinician or pharmacist.

## Try This Now

After any VA appointment where you received a new diagnosis or medication, try this:

"A clinician discussed [condition]. Without diagnosing me or recommending treatment changes, Can you explain in plain language:

what this condition is, what causes it, what the standard treatment approaches are, and what questions I should ask at my next appointment?"

Or: "Using an official medication guide or label that I provide, explain what it's for, how it works, what the common side effects are, and what I should watch for?"

Important: AI medical explanations help you understand. They don't replace your VA doctor's advice for your specific situation. Always discuss treatment decisions with your provider.

## **Preparing Questions for VA Appointments**

Studies consistently show that patients who come to medical appointments with prepared questions get more out of those appointments - more information, more engagement from their providers, better adherence to treatment plans.

AI can help you build a thorough, organized question list before any VA appointment. Describe your current situation and concerns, and ask AI to help you build the questions that will get you the most useful answers from your limited appointment time.

### **SAMPLE PROMPT: APPOINTMENT PREPARATION**

"I have a VA appointment next week with my primary care provider. My main concerns are: [describe your concerns]. I'm currently on [medications].

My last appointment I was told [what you were told]. Help me build a list of questions that will get me the most useful information from a 20-minute appointment."

Pro tip: Ask AI to prioritize the list. Appointments often run short. Know which questions matter most and lead with those.

## Understanding Your Rights as a VA Patient

Veterans have specific rights within the VA healthcare system that many don't fully know. AI can explain these clearly:

**The MISSION Act Community Care:** If the VA cannot provide timely or geographically accessible care, you may be eligible for care from a community (non-VA) provider at VA expense. Review VA's current Community Care eligibility page and ask your care team whether you qualify. AI may help explain a public passage but should not determine eligibility.

**Patient advocacy:** Every VA facility has a Patient Advocate who can help resolve issues with your care. If you're having problems getting appointments, referrals, or appropriate care, the Patient Advocate is your resource.

**Appeals for healthcare decisions:** If the VA denies a treatment or referral, you have the right to appeal. Ask AI to explain the healthcare appeals process.

## Using VA Digital Tools with AI Help

The VA's digital ecosystem - VA.gov, My HealtheVet, the VA Health and Benefits mobile app - has improved significantly but remains complex. AI can help you navigate these tools more effectively.

Use current VA.gov instructions - or ask AI to explain those instructions - to send a secure message through My HealtheVet on VA.gov, request a prescription refill, review your medical records, schedule appointments online, access your lab results, and use the VA Health and Benefits app for claims status and appointment management.

## AI Ally

### VA Patient Advocates

Every VA medical center has a Patient Advocate whose job is to help veterans navigate problems with their healthcare. If you're experiencing appointment delays, care coordination issues, or

problems with referrals, the Patient Advocate is a free internal resource. Find your facility's advocate at [va.gov/find-locations](https://va.gov/find-locations) or ask at the facility's front desk.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 AI translates medical language - diagnoses, lab results, medications - into plain language you can understand and act on.
- 2 Prepared appointment questions consistently improve the quality and usefulness of medical visits. Use AI to build yours.
- 3 The MISSION Act Community Care program may allow you to receive care from non-VA providers at VA expense if VA care is not timely or accessible.
- 4 VA digital tools (VA.gov, My HealtheVet, VA app) are navigable with AI guidance - ask AI to walk you through any specific function.
- 5 Every VA facility has a Patient Advocate - a free resource for navigating care problems.

## **Chapter 8: Mental Health, PTSD, and Digital Support Tools**

If you are in immediate danger, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department. For the Veterans Crisis Line, call 988 and press 1, text 838255, or use [VeteransCrisisLine.net](https://VeteransCrisisLine.net).

AI is not therapy, diagnosis, crisis intervention, or clinical care. A conversational system may respond inconsistently, retain data under terms you have not reviewed, and fail to recognize risk. Do not rely on it to assess whether you or someone else is safe.

### **Evidence-Based Digital Support**

VA and DoD offer free self-management applications such as PTSD Coach, PTSD Family Coach, Insomnia Coach, Mindfulness Coach, and Safety Plan. These are structured support tools, not necessarily generative AI, and they do not replace professional evaluation or treatment. Verify the current app list through VA's National Center for PTSD.

Commercial mental-health chatbots change availability and terms. For example, the consumer Woebot application was retired in 2025. Do not recommend a commercial tool solely because an older study or app-store listing exists. Review current access, privacy practices, clinical claims, and crisis limitations.

### **Appropriate Uses of General AI**

Lower-risk uses include creating a list of questions for a provider, explaining public information about established treatments, or helping draft a non-emergency appointment request. Avoid entering trauma narratives, identifying health information, medication lists, or crisis disclosures into a general-purpose service unless you have deliberately reviewed and accepted its privacy implications.

## Accessing Care

VA's PTSD Coach is designed to support symptom management and learning, not replace care. Vet Centers and VA mental-health services offer human support. Community Care may be available when eligibility requirements are met, including certain access standards; authorization is generally required for non-emergency care.

For non-VA emergency care, seek help immediately when life or health is in danger. VA payment is not automatic. Eligibility and notification rules apply, and VA generally must be notified within 72 hours after emergency care begins.

## Chapter Summary

- 1 General AI is not a mental-health provider or crisis service.
- 2 Prefer current VA and DoD self-management tools with clearly stated purposes and limits.
- 3 Protect trauma and health information.
- 4 Call 988 and press 1, text 838255, or use VeteransCrisisLine.net for the Veterans Crisis Line.
- 5 Emergency care comes first, but VA coverage depends on current eligibility and notification rules.



# Part Four

# Chapter 9: Education Benefits and AI as a Study Tool

Education programs differ in eligibility, payment method, time limits, and approved uses. AI can help build comparison questions, but VA's eligibility decision and the school's certification control.

## Major Programs to Compare

- **Post-9/11 GI Bill (Chapter 33):** May cover tuition and fees, a monthly housing allowance, and books and supplies according to the veteran's eligibility tier, rate of pursuit, course format, and other rules. The housing payment is not simply the member's former BAH.
- **Montgomery GI Bill-Active Duty (Chapter 30):** Generally pays a monthly amount directly to the student. Eligibility and the better financial choice depend on the individual record and program.
- **Veteran Readiness and Employment (Chapter 31):** A veteran with at least a 10% service-connected rating may be eligible to apply. A Vocational Rehabilitation Counselor determines entitlement and the appropriate services based on employment needs; education is one possible service, not an automatic benefit.
- **Dependents' Educational Assistance (Chapter 35):** Available to certain spouses and children of veterans or service members who meet statutory conditions.

Transfer of Post-9/11 GI Bill benefits is governed by DoD and generally must be requested while the service member is on active duty or in the Selected Reserve, with service obligations and limited exceptions. A veteran ordinarily cannot initiate a new transfer after separation.

## **A Safer Comparison Prompt**

“Using the current VA education pages I provide, create a comparison table for Chapters 30, 31, 33, and 35. Separate eligibility to apply from entitlement, identify questions VA or a school certifying official must answer, and do not tell me which program I qualify for.”

## **AI as a Study Tool**

AI can explain concepts, create practice questions, or give feedback on an outline. It can also invent sources and violate course rules when used improperly. Follow the institution's academic-integrity and disclosure policies. Verify citations in the original source and keep the analysis and final work your own.

Military training may receive credit based on ACE recommendations and an institution's policies. The college - not AI - decides what it accepts. Submit the appropriate Joint Services Transcript or CCAF transcript and confirm the result with the school.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 Compare education programs using current VA information and official counseling.
- 2 Eligibility to apply for VR&E does not guarantee entitlement or a particular course of education.
- 3 GI Bill transfers generally must be initiated while serving.
- 4 Follow academic-integrity rules and verify every source.
- 5 Institutions decide how military learning applies to a degree.

# Chapter 10: Career Transition: From Military to Civilian with AI

The military gives you skills that the civilian world desperately needs: leadership under pressure, logistics management, team coordination, technical expertise, mission planning, personnel management, and the ability to function effectively in ambiguous, high-stakes situations.

It gives you almost no help communicating those skills to civilian employers.

The translation problem is real. "Led a twelve-person team conducting combat operations" and "managed a

cross-functional team delivering results under time and resource constraints" describe the same person. One gets past a hiring manager's eye. One doesn't. AI can be a useful drafting tool for bridging that language gap.

## Translating Your MOS/Rate into Civilian Language

Military occupational specialties develop skills that may have civilian applications - but the language is entirely different. A 68W Army Combat Medic doesn't apply for "combat medic" jobs. They apply for EMT, paramedic, medical assistant, emergency services coordinator, or healthcare technician roles. An 11B Infantryman doesn't describe themselves as "specialized in armed conflict" - they describe themselves as a team leader with personnel management, logistics, and high-pressure decision-making experience.

## MOS TRANSLATION PROMPT

"I served as a [MOS/rate/AFSC and title] in the [branch] for [X] years. My key responsibilities included: [list 3-5 things you actually did]. I left as [rank].

Please:

- 1 Translate my role into civilian job titles I should be searching for
- 2 Rewrite my responsibilities in civilian résumé language
- 3 Identify the civilian industries where my skills are most valued
- 4 Suggest 3 specific companies or types of employers that actively recruit veterans with my background"

This prompt can generate possibilities to evaluate against real job descriptions, licensing requirements, and personal qualifications.

## **Building a Civilian Résumé with AI**

Civilian résumés follow conventions that are largely foreign to military culture: specific format requirements, quantified achievements, industry-specific keywords for applicant tracking systems, and the expectation of a personal brand summary at the top.

AI can help you build a strong civilian résumé from scratch - but the process works best interactively. Tell AI your background, your target roles, and your key achievements. Work through it section by section. Ask AI to identify military jargon to replace and keywords for your target industry to add.

## **Federal Jobs: Veterans' Preference and USAJOBS**

Federal employment may involve veterans' preference and several distinct hiring authorities. Schedule A is a disability hiring authority, while VRA has its own covered-veteran requirements, and career paths that often value military experience directly. USAJOBS is the main portal for competitive federal civilian vacancies, though not every federal position is posted there.

Ask AI to explain veterans' preference point categories (0-point, 5-point, 10-point), Schedule A non-competitive hiring authority, and how to write a strong federal

résumé (which is different from a private sector résumé in specific ways).

## **Interview Preparation with AI**

AI is an exceptional interview preparation tool. It can generate realistic interview questions for any role, help you develop strong STAR-format answers (Situation, Task, Action, Result) from your military experience, and give you feedback on your responses.

### **Try This Now**

Try this the week before any job interview:

"I'm interviewing for a [job title] position at [type of company]. My background is [brief military background]. Generate 10 likely interview questions for this role and help me develop strong answers that translate my military experience into terms a civilian hiring manager will value."

Then: Run through the answers out loud. Ask AI for feedback. "Here's how I answered question 3: [your answer]. How can I improve it?"

### **Real Talk**

In this illustrative composite, Carlos had been trying to break into civilian project management for fourteen months. He'd applied to dozens of jobs without callbacks. He described himself on his résumé as 'former Army logistics NCO.'

A friend suggested he try AI for his résumé. He spent one evening with Claude, describing his actual work: managing a 47-person logistics operation, tracking \$4.2M in equipment accountability, coordinating supply chains across three forward operating bases, training and evaluating personnel.

Claude translated all of it. The résumé he sent out the following week described a 'logistics operations manager with 9 years directing supply chain operations for a 47- member team across multiple distributed locations, maintaining 100% accountability of \$4.2M in assets.'

After revising the résumé and checking every claim against his records, he began receiving callbacks. Results vary by qualifications, labor market, application quality, and employer decisions.

'The work was the same,' he said. 'The words were just finally right.'

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 The translation problem is real - AI bridges the gap between military language and civilian hiring expectations faster than any other tool.
- 2 MOS translation prompts produce civilian job titles, résumé language, target industries, and employer suggestions in minutes.
- 3 Federal employment offers veterans' preference and special hiring authorities - AI can explain how to use them.
- 4 AI interview preparation - generating questions, developing STAR answers, reviewing responses - can be a useful career application when the user supplies accurate experience and reviews the result.
- 5 Your military experience has civilian value. The work is the same. The words need to change.

# **Chapter 11: Financial Benefits: VA, Federal, and Beyond**

Financial programs are governed by detailed eligibility rules. Use AI to create questions and explain official passages, not to calculate entitlement or recommend an election.

## **VA Disability Compensation and Related Benefits**

A disability evaluation may affect access to other programs, but percentage alone rarely answers every eligibility question. Dependency and Indemnity Compensation, Special Monthly Compensation, health-care priority, and state benefits each have separate rules.

## **CRDP and CRSC**

Concurrent Retirement and Disability Pay generally restores retired pay for qualifying military retirees with a VA disability rating of at least 50%. Combat-Related Special Compensation is a tax-free special compensation for qualifying combat-related disabilities and requires an application through the service branch. Retirement category, years of service, reserve retirement age, disability retirement, offsets, and tax treatment can change the result.

A retiree may qualify for both programs but receive only one at a time. DFAS may initially select the larger gross entitlement and provides an annual election opportunity in appropriate cases. Gross payment is not the only consideration, so consult DFAS, the service branch, and a qualified tax or financial professional.

## **Social Security Disability Insurance**

VA and Social Security use different disability standards. A VA award does not guarantee SSDI, and SSDI requires sufficient work history plus an impairment meeting Social Security's definition of disability.



SSA has separate expedited-processing categories for veterans rated 100% Permanent and Total and for qualifying Wounded Warriors whose disability began while on active duty on or after October 1, 2001. Expedited processing does not change the eligibility standard.

## **VA Home Loan Guaranty**

Eligible borrowers may be able to purchase without a down payment when the price does not exceed the property's reasonable value and lender requirements are met. There is no monthly private mortgage insurance requirement, but closing costs, the funding fee unless exempt, appraisal limits, credit, income, and remaining entitlement still matter. Obtain a Certificate of Eligibility and compare qualified lenders.

## **Special Monthly Compensation**

SMC is additional compensation for qualifying severe disabilities, combinations of disabilities, or circumstances such as aid and attendance or housebound status. The categories are technical. Review current VA guidance and obtain accredited help instead of asking AI to determine qualification.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 Related benefits have separate eligibility rules.
- 2 CRDP and CRSC depend on retirement and disability details; only one may be received at a time.
- 3 VA and SSA disability standards are different.
- 4 Expedited SSA processing does not guarantee approval.
- 5 Confirm home-loan and SMC questions with official sources and qualified professionals.

# Part Five

# **Chapter 12: Federal Government Services for Veterans**

Federal programs outside VA are administered by different agencies with different definitions and evidence requirements. AI can organize official information, but it cannot create eligibility across programs.

## **Social Security Programs**

Social Security Disability Insurance is based on insured status and Social Security's disability standard. Supplemental Security Income is needs-based and has income and resource rules. Some people become entitled to Medicare after receiving qualifying Social Security disability benefits for the applicable waiting period, with special rules and exceptions. VA compensation and health care do not replace the need to understand Social Security and Medicare enrollment rules.

SSA separately identifies claims for expedited processing when a veteran has a 100% Permanent and Total VA rating or meets the Wounded Warrior criteria. Expedited processing changes priority, not the disability standard.

## **Department of Labor Employment Programs**

American Job Centers provide employment and training services. Eligible veterans and spouses receive priority of service under applicable rules, but priority does not guarantee a particular job, training award, or immediate appointment. Jobs for Veterans State Grants fund staff who serve eligible veterans and spouses, particularly people facing significant barriers to employment. The HIRE Vets Medallion Program recognizes participating employers; an award is not a guarantee about a specific vacancy or workplace.

## **Small Business and Federal Contracting**

SBA provides veteran entrepreneurship education and administers certification for eligible veteran-owned and service-disabled veteran-owned small businesses through VetCert. Certification does not guarantee a contract. A business must also satisfy ownership, control, size, solicitation, registration, responsibility, and performance requirements.

Use SAM.gov for entity registration and federal contract opportunities. Be cautious of firms charging unnecessary fees for free government registration or promising guaranteed awards.

## **Military Records**

The National Archives provides official routes for requesting DD-214s and other military personnel records. The 1973 NPRC fire affected certain Army and Air Force records, and reconstruction procedures may be available. A discharge review or correction request is a separate process handled by the appropriate military review board.

## **A Safer Research Prompt**

“Using only the current official agency pages I provide, organize the program requirements, application steps, documents, and questions I should ask. Distinguish eligibility to apply from approval, and do not infer eligibility from my VA rating.”

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1 VA, SSA, DOL, SBA, and DoD programs use different eligibility rules.
- 2 Expedited SSA processing does not change the disability standard.
- 3 Priority of service and employer recognition do not guarantee employment.
- 4 VetCert certification does not guarantee a federal contract.
- 5 Request military records and corrections through the responsible official channel.

# Chapter 13: State and Local Government Services for Veterans

State, county, and municipal programs vary widely. A benefit available in one jurisdiction may not exist in another, and labels such as “disabled veteran” or “Permanent and Total” do not have identical effects everywhere.

## Common Categories

Programs may include partial property-tax exclusions, education assistance, hiring preferences, occupational-licensing support, reduced recreation fees, specialty license plates, veterans treatment courts, legal assistance, burial benefits, and county veterans service offices. Eligibility may depend on residence, discharge character, disability percentage, income, wartime service, application date, or whether the benefit was claimed before a deadline.

Do not rely on a national summary or an AI-generated list for a tax or enrollment decision. For example, a “property-tax exemption” may exclude only part of a home's assessed value rather than eliminate the entire bill.

## Build a Verification Map

- 1 Start with the official state veterans agency and tax agency.
- 2 Check the county assessor, clerk, veterans service office, and relevant city pages.
- 3 Record the program name, governing agency, eligibility language, deadline, required proof, and official URL.
- 4 Call the administering office when wording is unclear.
- 5 Recheck after a move, rating change, change in family status, or annual program update.

**Prompt:** “Using only the official government pages I provide, organize these programs into a verification table. Include eligibility language, application office, deadline, documents, and questions I still need to ask. Do not decide whether I qualify.”

## Chapter Summary

- 1 State and local benefits are highly jurisdiction-specific.
- 2 Similar program names can represent very different financial value.
- 3 Begin with official state and local agencies.
- 4 Use AI to organize verified information, not invent a comprehensive list.
- 5 Recheck programs when circumstances or rules change.

# Part Six

# Chapter 14: Scams Targeting Veterans

Veterans may encounter benefit, pension, employment, investment, charity, identity-theft, and impersonation schemes. Avoid unsupported claims about how veterans compare statistically with every other population; focus on recognizable conduct and verification.

## Claims Assistance and Accreditation

Recognized VSO representatives provide claims assistance without charging the claimant. VA-accredited attorneys and claims agents may charge qualifying fees only after VA has issued an initial decision and the applicable appointment and fee-agreement rules are satisfied. Verify the individual - not merely the organization's name - through VA's accreditation search.

Treat guaranteed ratings, instructions to exaggerate symptoms, demands for account credentials, and contracts assigning an excessive share of future benefits as serious warnings. Never give an adviser your VA.gov password or multifactor code.

## Pension, Discharge, Debt, and Impersonation Schemes

Be cautious when someone recommends moving assets primarily to qualify for a needs-based pension, especially when the recommendation involves high commissions, surrender charges, or loss of control. Obtain independent advice from an accredited representative and an appropriately credentialed fiduciary professional.

Military review boards do not charge an application fee for a discharge review or correction request, though a veteran may choose paid legal representation. Free or pro bono help may be available. Verify organizations and understand the scope and price before signing.



An unexpected payment demand is not proof of a VA debt. Do not use a number, link, or payment method supplied by the caller. Sign in through VA.gov or contact the official VA Debt Management Center or benefits number using contact information you independently locate.

## **If You Are Targeted**

Preserve messages, contracts, receipts, phone numbers, and payment records. Contact the bank or payment provider promptly if money moved. Change compromised credentials from a known-clean device. Report relevant conduct through official VA, VA OIG, FTC, state, or law-enforcement channels. A report does not guarantee recovery.

## **Chapter Summary**

- 1    Verify representatives through VA's official accreditation search.
- 2    VSO representation is free; attorney and agent fees are governed by specific post-decision rules.
- 3    Guaranteed outcomes, credential requests, and pressure are serious warnings.
- 4    Verify debts and payment instructions through independently located official channels.
- 5    Preserve evidence and act promptly when information or money is compromised.

# Chapter 15: Your AI Action Plan for Veterans

The safest workflow is simple: official source, careful explanation, human review when stakes are high, and a record of what you verified.

## Ten Actions

- 1 Choose one general-purpose AI tool and review its privacy and data-control settings.
- 2 Create a de-identified list of your current questions; do not upload a DD-214, decision letter, full medical record, Social Security number, claim number, or login credential.
- 3 Save VA's official disability-evidence and decision-review pages.
- 4 Locate and verify an accredited representative if you need claims help.
- 5 Build a source log for benefits research, including access dates.
- 6 Save the Veterans Crisis Line: call 988 and press 1, text 838255, or use [VeteransCrisisLine.net](https://www.veteranscrisisline.net).
- 7 Review My HealtheVet on [VA.gov](https://www.va.gov) and the VA Health and Benefits application using current VA instructions.
- 8 Compare education, career, or financial programs through the administering agency - not an AI eligibility verdict.
- 9 Check official state and county veteran-benefit pages.
- 10 Share one verified resource with another veteran.

## Reusable Prompt Pattern

“I will provide a current official government page. Explain it in plain language, distinguish direct statements from interpretation, identify dates and exceptions, and list questions for the administering agency or an accredited professional. Do not decide eligibility, predict an outcome, or invent missing facts.”

## Master Resource Principles

- Navigate to sensitive accounts through a saved bookmark or independently typed official address.
- Confirm forms, deadlines, payment rates, and phone numbers when you use them.
- Treat AI-generated citations as unverified until the cited page opens and supports the statement.
- Preserve the final decision letter or agency notice; it controls over a general summary.
- Seek immediate human help for crises, deadlines, suspected fraud, or consequential medical and financial decisions.

## A Final Word

AI can reduce friction. It can help turn a dense paragraph into questions, organize a checklist, and make a first draft clearer. It cannot earn credibility by sounding confident. That credibility comes from accurate facts, current sources, and accountable human judgment.

Use the tool. Keep control of the facts. Verify what matters.

## Chapter Summary

- 1 Protect identifying, medical, military, and financial information.
- 2 Begin consequential research with an official source.
- 3 Use AI for explanation and organization, not eligibility or outcome decisions.

- 4 Bring unresolved high-stakes questions to the responsible agency or qualified professional.
- 5 Keep a dated source log because rules and programs change.

# Glossary

## VA AND MILITARY TERMS

### **BVA (Board of Veterans' Appeals)**

The administrative body within the VA that hears appeals of denied claims. Veterans Law Judges review claims and issue written decisions.

### **C&P Examination**

Compensation and Pension examination. A medical evaluation conducted by VA or VA-contracted physicians to assess the nature and severity of a claimed condition.

### **CAVC (Court of Appeals for Veterans Claims)**

An independent federal court that reviews final Board decisions. Representation is not legally required, but experienced legal assistance is strongly advisable.

### **CFR Title 38**

Code of Federal Regulations, Title 38 - the federal regulations governing veterans benefits, including the Schedule for Rating Disabilities (Part 4).

### **Combined Rating**

The VA's formula for calculating a total disability percentage when multiple conditions are rated. Uses a 'whole person' calculation, not simple addition.

### **CRSC (Combat-Related Special Compensation)**

Additional DoD compensation for military retirees with combat-related disabilities, paid tax-free.

## **CRDP (Concurrent Retirement and Disability Pay)**

Restoration of retired pay for qualifying military retirees who generally have VA disability ratings of at least 50%, subject to detailed eligibility rules.

## **DD-214**

Certificate of Release or Discharge from Active Duty. The primary document certifying a veteran's military service. Essential for nearly all benefit claims.

## **DIC (Dependency and Indemnity Compensation)**

VA compensation paid to surviving spouses and dependents of veterans who died from service-connected conditions.

## **HLR (Higher-Level Review)**

An appeals lane in which a senior VA reviewer re-examines a denied claim without new evidence.

## **Lay Evidence**

Evidence from non-medical sources - personal statements, buddy statements - describing observed facts rather than medical opinions.

## **MST (Military Sexual Trauma)**

Sexual assault or repeated, threatening sexual harassment that occurred while on active duty or training. VA provides free mental health treatment for MST-related conditions.

## **Nexus**

The connection between a current disability and service. The necessary evidence depends on the claim and may include medical evidence, competent lay evidence, or an applicable presumption.

## **P&T (Permanent and Total)**

A VA disability status designation for veterans rated 100% whose conditions are permanent. Unlocks additional benefits including property tax exemptions in many states.

## **PACT Act**

Sergeant First Class Heath Robinson Honoring our Promise to Address Comprehensive Toxics Act of 2022. Dramatically expanded VA benefits for veterans exposed to burn pits and other toxic substances.

## **Presumptive Condition**

A condition the VA presumes is service-connected based on specific exposures or service locations, without requiring the veteran to prove a nexus.

## **Secondary Service Connection**

Service connection for a condition caused or aggravated by an already service-connected condition.

## **SMC (Special Monthly Compensation)**

Additional VA compensation above standard rates for veterans with especially severe disabilities or specific combinations of conditions.

## **SDVOSB (Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business)**

A federal certification for veteran-owned businesses where the owner has a service-connected disability. Provides access to federal contracting set-asides.

## **VSO (Veterans Service Organization)**

An organization accredited by VA to provide free claims representation to veterans. Major VSOs include DAV, VFW, American Legion, and AMVETS.

## **VR&E (Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment)**

VA employment and independent-living program (Chapter 31) for eligible service members and veterans with service-connected disabilities. A counselor determines entitlement and appropriate services.

## **AI TERMS**

### **AI (Artificial Intelligence)**

Software trained on large amounts of data to recognize patterns and generate useful outputs - including text, analysis, and research summaries.

### **Chatbot**

An AI-powered conversational program. General-purpose AI tools like ChatGPT and Claude are sophisticated chatbots capable of complex reasoning and document analysis.

### **Hallucination**

The tendency of AI systems to generate false or inaccurate information confidently. Always verify important facts from official sources.

### **Large Language Model (LLM)**

The underlying AI technology powering tools like ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini. Trained on vast amounts of text to generate human-like responses.

### **Prompt**

The question, instruction, or input you provide to an AI tool. More specific, context-rich prompts produce more useful responses.



# Trusted Resources and Sources

## VA Claims and Representation

- VA disability evidence requirements: <https://www.va.gov/disability/how-to-file-claim/evidence-needed/>
- VA decision-review FAQs: <https://www.va.gov/resources/decision-reviews-faqs/>
- VA claim examinations: <https://www.va.gov/resources/va-claim-exam/>
- Find an accredited representative: <https://www.va.gov/get-help-from-accredited-representative/>
- Current Schedule for Rating Disabilities: <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-38/chapter-I/part-4>
- PACT Act information: <https://www.va.gov/resources/the-pact-act-and-your-vb-benefits/>

## Healthcare and Mental Health

- My HealtheVet on VA.gov: <https://www.va.gov/my-health/>
- VA Community Care: <https://www.va.gov/COMMUNITYCARE/>
- Non-VA emergency care requirements: <https://www.va.gov/resources/getting-emergency-care-at-non-vb-facilities/>
- VA National Center for PTSD applications: <https://www.ptsd.va.gov/appvid/mobile/>
- Veterans Crisis Line: <https://www.veteranscrisisline.net/>

## Education, Employment, and Financial Programs

- Compare VA education benefits: <https://www.va.gov/education/compare-benefits/>
- Transfer Post-9/11 GI Bill benefits: [https://benefits.va.gov/gibill/post911\\_transfer.asp](https://benefits.va.gov/gibill/post911_transfer.asp)

- Veteran Readiness and Employment: <https://www.va.gov/careers-employment/vocational-rehabilitation/>
- Federal veteran hiring information: <https://www.opm.gov/fedshirevets/>
- Social Security information for veterans: <https://www.ssa.gov/people/veterans/>
- DFAS CRDP and CRSC comparison: <https://www.dfas.mil/retiredmilitary/disability/comparison/>
- VA-backed home loans: <https://www.va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/>

## **Federal, State, and Consumer Resources**

- Veterans' employment resources: <https://www.dol.gov/agencies/vets>
- SBA veteran contracting programs: <https://www.sba.gov/federal-contracting/contracting-assistance-programs/veteran-contracting-assistance-programs>
- Military records: <https://www.archives.gov/veterans>
- System for Award Management: <https://sam.gov/>
- VA Office of Inspector General: <https://www.vaoig.gov/>
- FTC fraud reporting: <https://reportfraud.ftc.gov/>

Commercial AI products and applications change frequently. Verify current availability, cost, privacy terms, and capabilities on the provider's official site before recommending one.

# About the Author

Patrick Thomas is an author, veteran, facilities management professional, and technology enthusiast focused on making artificial intelligence practical and approachable for everyday people.

His AI Guide Series was created for readers who want clear explanations, useful examples, and real-world ways to use AI without technical jargon or unnecessary complexity.

Patrick writes practical guides for people who want to understand new technology, use it responsibly, and apply it to work, home, safety, learning, and everyday problem-solving.

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Build your AI skills one guide at a time.